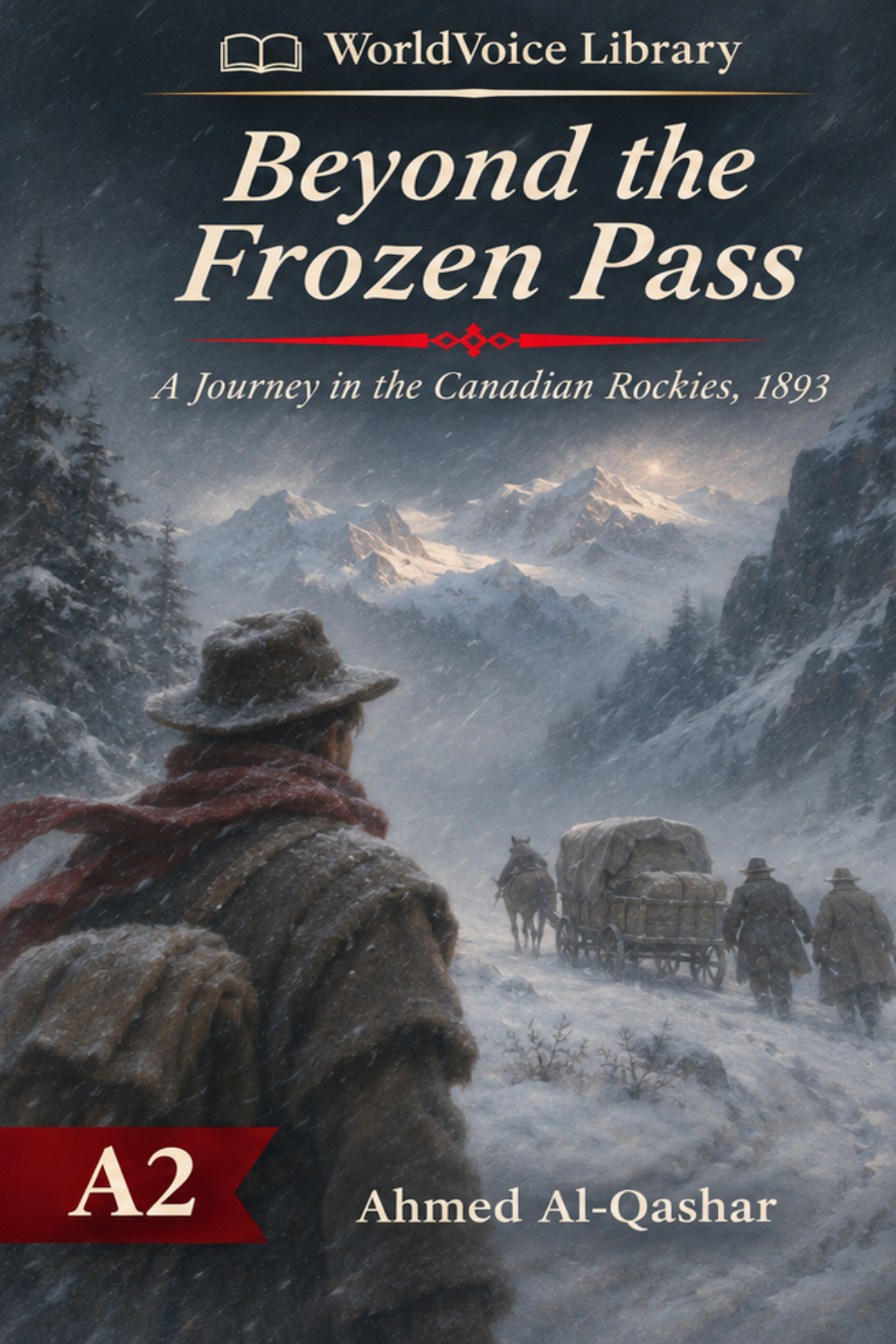

WorldVoice Library
Beyond the Frozen Pass
A Journey in the Canadian Rockies, 1893
A2
Ahmed Al-Qashar

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# Beyond the Frozen Pass

*A Journey in the Canadian Rockies, 1893*

Written by

Ahmed Al-Qashar

ENGLISH GRADED READERS

A2 · Elementary

An original WorldVoice Library novel

Editorial review edition · 2026

# Publication & Rights

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WorldVoice Library - English Graded Readers, A2.

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The A2 level is the intended learning level. It has not been independently certified; language and historical review are recommended before commercial publication.

This editorial review edition has no ISBN and is not a commercial release.

Book format: 6 × 9 inches. Interior: black text on white pages.

Read · Learn · Explore

# Story Introduction

*Six travelers. A mountain pass. Winter on the way.*

It is October 1893. Rose Carter and her younger brother Will must leave the small town of Pine Crossing for a new life in Silver Creek. Four other travelers join them, and the experienced guide Caleb Ward leads the group toward Falcon Pass.

But the Canadian Rockies are changing as winter arrives. A broken bridge, dangerous water, deep snow, and a difficult choice threaten their journey. Food is limited, and not everyone agrees about the safest road.

The travelers must learn to listen to one another, share what they have, and find courage even when they are afraid. Reaching the other side will change more than their plans.

# Before You Read

1. What dangers can people face when crossing high mountains?

2. Why might a group travel together instead of alone?

3. What could you do if your plans changed because of bad weather?

# Characters

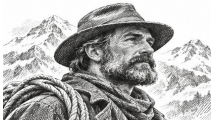
*The people you will meet in the story*



**Rose Carter**
A young teacher leaving Pine Crossing to begin work at a new school. She is thoughtful, patient, and brave.



**Will Carter**
Rose's sixteen-year-old brother. He dreams of learning to repair railway engines.



**Caleb Ward**
An experienced mountain guide, careful with weather and difficult decisions.



**Agnes Doyle**
A lively former innkeeper who takes care of food, blankets, and everyone's spirits.

**Samuel (Sam) Reed**
A young timber worker who wants to reach his sister's family quickly.

**Jonah Finch**
A stable worker who looks after the animals and knows the brown mule Queen.

**Henry Ellis**
A bridge repairer who warns the travelers about the icy high road.

**Ellen Reed**
Sam's sister, waiting for him and his help at Silver Creek.

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Read all nine chapters before checking the answer key.

CHAPTER 1

# Chapter 1: The Road Before Winter

In the last week of October 1893, a cold wind moved through the little town of Pine Crossing. The mountains stood high above its roofs. Their tops were already white, but the road through the valley was still brown. People said winter would arrive soon. Nobody knew exactly when.

Rose Carter stood outside the small school with a wooden box in her arms. Inside the box were her books, a cracked cup, and a bell with a broken handle. She had taught in that school for two years. Now the owner of the building had closed it. Most of the families had left the town, and there were not enough children for another winter.



"You can leave the bell," said Will, her younger brother. "It does not work."

"The bell still has a sound," Rose answered. She shook it, and it gave a small, thin ring. "Besides, I carried it here. I can carry it away."

Will was sixteen and wanted to be treated like a man. He took the box from her hands before she could argue. "Then I will carry it."

They were going to Silver Creek, a railway settlement on the far side of Falcon Pass. Rose had been offered work in another school. Will hoped to learn how to repair railway engines. A train could take them farther west from Silver Creek, but first they had to reach the station. The main wagon road was much longer. People who knew the mountain often used the pass before the first heavy snow.

At the stable, four other travelers waited beside two horses and a strong brown mule. Caleb Ward, their guide, was a tall man of forty-four. He had a grey beard, a heavy coat, and quiet eyes. Agnes Doyle, who had once kept the town's inn, stood near a pile of blankets. She was fifty-two, but she moved quickly and spoke more quickly still. Samuel Reed was a young timber worker with broad shoulders. He called himself Sam and disliked standing still. The sixth traveler was Jonah Finch, a nineteen-year-old who had helped at the stable since he was a boy.

"We should go now," Sam said. "The day is getting away from us."

"The mountain will still be there in ten minutes," Agnes replied. "Check the food first."

Caleb had put flour, oats, beans, tea, dried apples, and a little salt into three canvas bags. One bag held a small pan and a kettle.

Another held spare socks and the group's matches. The third held tools and a long coil of rope. Their clothes and blankets were tied behind the saddles. They had enough food for five careful days. The journey should take four, but Caleb wanted one extra day in case the weather changed.

"Why only five?" Will asked.

"Because a horse can carry only so much," Caleb said. "And on a narrow path, a heavy animal can be dangerous."

Jonah checked each rope. "The mule is called Queen," he said. "She is cleverer than I am. If she stops, look at the ground before you tell her to move."

Rose smiled, but Caleb did not. He was looking at the cloud around the highest peak. It was a small cloud, no larger than a hand from where they stood. He watched it for a long time.

"Is something wrong?" Rose asked.

"There will be snow," he said. "There always is. The question is how much, and where."

Sam pointed to the western ridge. "The sky is clear over there."

"A clear sky behind one hill tells you little about the next hill," Caleb answered.

They left just after sunrise. Pine Crossing became smaller behind them. A dog followed for a short distance, then turned back. The road went past the sawmill, the empty church, and a line of dark pine trees. When they reached the first bridge, Rose stopped to look behind her. Smoke rose from only three houses. The town already looked like a place in a story.

"Are you sorry to leave?" Will asked.

"A little," she answered. "We had good days here."

"There will be good days in Silver Creek."

"I hope so."

Agnes walked beside them and heard the last words. "Hope is useful," she said. "But dry boots are useful too. Check your feet before lunch."

That was the first lesson of the journey. The next lesson came when the path turned away from the warm valley and began to climb. In the trees, the wind sounded like water. High above them, a dark line of clouds crossed the morning sun.

CHAPTER 2

# Chapter 2: The Warning at Birch Creek

On the second morning the travelers reached Birch Creek. The creek was narrow, and stones showed through its clear water. A wooden cabin stood near the bank. Its door was open, and a thin man in a brown coat sat outside, cutting a piece of wood with a knife.

Caleb raised his hand. "Morning, Mr. Ellis."



The man looked up. His name was Henry Ellis, and he repaired bridges along the old forest road. He lived alone during the warmer months. His face was red from the cold.

"You are late in the year," he said. "Too late for the high road, perhaps."

"We are going to Silver Creek," Caleb answered. "Four days, if the weather holds."

Henry shook his head. "I walked to the upper ridge yesterday. Ice has covered the stones beside White Creek. There was fresh snow above the line of the trees. I would take the long valley road."

"The valley road adds six days," Sam said.

"It adds six days when it is open," Henry replied. "A broken leg may add six months."

Rose looked at Caleb. He said nothing for a moment. He took off one glove and rubbed his forehead, as if he could feel the weather with his skin.

"What about the old miners' path?" he asked.

"The one below Raven Ridge? I have not seen it this year. It is narrow, but it stays under the trees for longer."

"That may help us."

Henry stood and walked to a wooden shelf beside the cabin. He brought back a little piece of paper. On it, he drew three lines with his pencil. One line was the main path. Another went around a high rock wall. The third crossed a river near a stone bridge.

"This is not a proper map," he said. "Only what I remember. At the second fork, look for a tree with two trunks. Go left there, not right. Right will take you to the old mine. There is no safe way down from it."

Will watched the pencil move. "How do you remember so many paths?"

"By walking them," Henry replied. "And sometimes by walking the wrong one."

Agnes asked if he had any news from Silver Creek. Henry said that a freight train had brought coal two weeks earlier, and the station was ready for winter. Rose felt better. The school where she would work was near that station. It seemed almost close enough to touch.

They ate bread and cheese beside the creek. Jonah gave Queen a handful of oats. The mule put her head against his shoulder and waited for more. "She knows who carries the food," Jonah said.

Sam spent the meal looking west. "If we stop every time someone has a story about bad weather, we will reach Silver Creek in spring."

"We stopped for information," Rose told him. "That is different."

Sam took a long breath. "My sister is waiting for me at the station. She has two children, and their father is ill. I have money for them from my work at the sawmill. I do not want to arrive after the snow closes the road."

His voice was quieter than before. Rose had thought he cared only about being first. She understood him better now. Everybody on the path was carrying something that could not be put in a canvas bag.

After lunch, a few white flakes moved between the trees. They did not stay on the ground. Will caught one on his glove, and it disappeared at once.

"That is hardly a storm," he said.

"No," Caleb agreed. "But it means the air above us is cold enough."

At the fork, the group found the tree with two trunks. The left path disappeared into thick forest. The right path looked wider and easier. Sam stood on the right and waited.

"Are you certain?" he asked.

"I am certain what Henry told us," Caleb said. "And I trust him."

They took the left path. It climbed slowly beside a steep hill. The trees grew taller, and little patches of snow lay in the shadows. Late in the afternoon, Rose noticed the first dark cloud above the western ridge. It was much larger than the cloud they had seen at Pine Crossing.

That evening they made camp behind a wall of stones. Jonah tied the horses close to the trees. Agnes cooked beans in the small pan and told a funny story about a guest at her inn who had tried to pay for dinner with a broken watch. Everybody laughed except Caleb, who listened to the wind.

"Will we be safe?" Rose asked him when the others had gone to sleep.

"I cannot promise that," he said. "I can promise we will pay attention."

CHAPTER 3

# Chapter 3: Water Under the Ice

White Creek was not white when the group first saw it. It was dark green, with fast water running between grey rocks. Pieces of ice floated near the edges. An old wooden bridge stood above the stream, but one side had fallen, and the middle boards were wet and bent.

"We cannot take the animals across that," Jonah said at once.



Caleb walked to the bridge and tested the first board with his boot. It moved under his weight. He stepped back. "We will find a safer place."

Sam looked at the water. "The creek is only a few steps across."

"A few steps in water this cold may be your last steps," Agnes answered.

They searched along the bank. The ground was soft and full of stones. Farther upstream, the creek became wider but less deep. It moved around a small island of sand. Caleb walked into the shallow edge with his staff and looked for firm ground beneath the water.

"Here," he said. "One animal at a time. No hurry."

Jonah led the first horse through the cold water. The horse stepped slowly, stopped once, and reached the other side. Rose and Will followed, holding their boots in their hands. The water was so cold that Rose could hardly feel her feet after a few seconds. Agnes shouted instructions from the near bank. It sounded as if she were directing a busy kitchen.

Then Queen entered the creek with Jonah. She carried two bags of food and the tools. She took three careful steps. On the fourth, her front foot slipped between two stones. She fell to her knees and tried to rise. One of the ropes broke. A bag dropped into the water and opened at the top.

"The flour!" Will cried.

Jonah moved toward the bag, but the current pulled at his legs. He lost his balance and fell sideways. His hat floated away. He reached for Queen's rope with one hand and a rock with the other.

"Leave the bag!" Caleb shouted.

Sam was already in the creek. He caught Jonah by the back of his coat. The current turned both of them, and for a terrible moment Rose thought they would fall under the water. Caleb reached them

with the end of the long rope. Sam grabbed it. Together, the people on the bank pulled the two young men to safety.

Queen finally stood. Jonah led her out, shaking with cold. The flour bag disappeared around a bend. The second bag was wet but still closed. Rose took off her coat and covered Jonah's shoulders. Agnes made him walk in a circle until he could move his fingers again.

"I should have tied the bag twice," Jonah said, looking at the ground.

"You tied the rope the right way," Caleb answered. "It broke on a sharp stone. That is not your fault. The important thing is that you are here."

Sam sat on a rock and emptied his boots. Water ran onto the ground. His hands were red. "That was a foolish place to cross," he said.

"It was the safest place we found," Caleb replied. "The mountain sometimes gives you a choice between two bad things. You take the smaller danger."

They counted the supplies. Half the flour was gone. The beans were wet, and Agnes spread them on a clean cloth to dry. Their matches had stayed safe inside a metal box. Everyone looked at that little box with new respect.

"We can still make food for several days," Agnes said. "But we must be careful. No extra bread after supper."

Will gave her a surprised look. "You always give us extra bread."

"Then you will understand how serious I am."

They walked another hour until they found dry ground beneath tall trees. Caleb helped Sam build a fire. Jonah sat near it with his boots off. When his feet were warm enough, he stood and bowed to Sam in a grand way.

"Thank you for saving my hat," he said.

Sam looked at him. "Your hat is halfway to the sea."

"Then thank you for saving the part underneath it."

They laughed, and the sound seemed louder than the water behind them.

That night Rose wrote a few lines in her notebook. She had meant to describe the mountains, but instead she wrote about the people. A guide who never hurried. An innkeeper who knew how to dry beans. A man who complained but jumped into cold water to save a friend. The mountains were beautiful, but they were not the most important part of the journey.

CHAPTER 4

# Chapter 4: The House Without a Door

The first heavy snow arrived before sunrise. It covered the ground around the camp and made the trees look like white towers. Caleb woke everybody while the sky was still dark. He wanted to move before the snow became deep.

"We need shelter higher up," he said. "There is an old workmen's house near the ridge. I used it years ago."



They walked slowly. The horses pushed through snow that reached their ankles. Queen did not complain, but she stopped often to shake the white powder from her nose. Rose found that carrying

her box of books was harder than carrying it along a town road. She tied the box to a saddle and kept only her notebook in her coat.

At noon they found the house. It stood among dark pines, with a low stone wall and a broken window. The door was missing. Snow lay on the floor near the entrance. A bird had built a nest in one corner of the roof.

"A fine hotel," Agnes said. "No door, no beds, and no guest book."

"It has walls," Caleb answered. "And that is enough for today."

They brought the animals into a small open shed beside the building. Then they cleaned the floor, closed the broken window with a blanket, and used two fallen boards to cover the entrance. Sam found dry wood beneath the roof. Soon a small fire burned in the stone fireplace.

Agnes opened the food bags and counted slowly. There were beans for two more meals, oats for the animals, six small pieces of bread, and a little tea. They had dried apples, but not many. The flour was almost gone. She put each kind of food on a cloth, so everybody could see what remained.

"We have three days of food if we eat little," she said. "Perhaps four, if we are very careful."

"Then we must leave in the morning," Sam answered.

"Not if the snow is deep," Caleb said.

Sam stood. "If we wait, we will use the food and still have the same mountain to cross."

"If we leave too soon, we may never use the food again."

The room became quiet. Nobody wanted to argue, but everybody was afraid. Will looked from one face to another. He had never seen grown people disagree about something so important.

Rose asked Caleb to show them the route. He used a piece of wood to draw lines in the ash near the fire. The main trail crossed the high pass. A second path ran through a long valley. The first was shorter but open to the wind. The second was longer, under the trees, and difficult to find.

"We cannot choose until we see the morning," Caleb said. "For tonight, we rest."

Agnes gave each person a small cup of hot beans. Sam was given no more than Will. He looked unhappy but said nothing. Later, when Rose was putting the cups away, she found Sam beside the fire, holding his last piece of bread.

"Take half," he said.

"I have my own."

"Will is still hungry. Give it to him and tell him you found it."

Rose took the bread. "You can tell him yourself."

Sam shook his head. "Then he will thank me, and I will have to say something kind. I am not good at that."

In the evening Agnes told another story from her old inn. This time nobody laughed very much. Snow blew through a small opening near the roof. Jonah closed it with a piece of cloth. Caleb checked the horses once more and came back with white hair and a face as cold as stone.

"We stay tomorrow," he said. "The wind is too strong."

The words made the little room feel smaller. Rose looked at the closed entrance and thought of her empty classroom at Pine Crossing. A room could be warm and still feel lonely. Yet here, in a broken house on a dangerous mountain, six strangers were learning how to be together.

Before sleeping, Will asked, "What if the snow does not stop?"

"It will," Rose said.

"How do you know?"

"I do not know when. But storms do not last forever."

It was not much of an answer. It was the best answer she had.

CHAPTER 5

# Chapter 5: The White Morning

The storm did not stop the next morning. It grew stronger. Snow struck the walls, and the old house shook in the wind. Caleb opened a small space between the boards at the door. Outside, the trees were little more than dark shadows.

"We wait," he said again.



Sam sat near the fire with his arms crossed. He had nothing to say. Jonah used a short piece of rope to repair a strap on Queen's saddle. Agnes warmed tea that was so weak Rose could almost see the bottom of the cup. Will tried to read one of his sister's books, but the words would not stay still in his mind.

At midday they heard a loud crack. It came from the shed outside. Jonah was on his feet at once.

"The animals!"

A branch had fallen onto the roof of the shed. The roof did not break, but one wooden post bent. Queen moved against the wall and made a frightened sound. Caleb took the rope and told everybody to stand back while he opened the door. He and Sam went into the snow. They tied a line around the weak post and pulled it toward a nearby tree.

Rose waited at the entrance. She could not see their feet. Snow moved around them like smoke. After several minutes Sam shouted for help. The branch was too heavy. Caleb needed another pair of hands.

"I can go," Will said.

"No," Rose answered quickly.

"I can hold a rope."

"You can help me from here," she said. "Hold this end and do not let it go."

Together they pulled. The rope became tight. Caleb pushed a board under the weak roof, and Sam tied it in place. They brought the animals closer to the house. Everyone returned cold and tired, but the roof stayed up.

For a little while, the room was full of happy noise. Agnes put hot water into a pan so the men could warm their hands. Then Jonah looked toward the entrance and became quiet. The wind had carried snow against the wall, almost to the top of the door.

"If it rises much more, we will not get out," he said.

Caleb took a short wooden shovel and began to clear a path. Sam joined him. They worked in turns. Every time a person came back inside, someone else went out. Rose learned how quickly a tired body could become warm near the fire and cold again in the wind.

That night the fire became smaller. There was less dry wood than they had expected. Caleb told them to keep one room warm rather than the whole house. They moved close together and covered their feet with the same blankets.

"We are six people," Agnes said. "We have six heads. Let us use them."

"For what?" Will asked.

"To think of useful things. One thing each. Not the trouble, but something we can do."

Jonah said he could repair the broken saddle. Sam said he could find wood beneath the snow when the wind stopped. Caleb said he would test the depth of the snow before choosing a route. Rose said she could keep a list of their supplies and count them fairly. Will said he would care for Queen and the horses. Agnes looked pleased.

"And I will make the little food taste like more food," she said.

They all smiled. It was a small plan. Yet a small plan was better than sitting in the dark and waiting for fear to grow.

Before dawn Rose heard a new sound. At first she thought it was the wind, but it was not. Water was falling from the roof. She went to the door and saw a thin line of light between the boards. The storm had passed.

Outside, the world was white and silent. The mountain stood under the morning sky. There was no road to see, only smooth snow and dark trees. Caleb came to stand beside her.

"Now comes the difficult part," he said.

"I thought that was the difficult part," Rose answered, looking back at the house.

"That was the waiting. Today we must choose."

CHAPTER 6

# Chapter 6: Two Roads, One Choice

Caleb left the old house alone at sunrise. He carried a staff and a long length of rope. The others watched him disappear between the trees. He had promised not to go farther than the first ridge, but Rose still felt worried.

After an hour he returned. Snow covered the front of his coat. He looked older than he had the day before.



"The high pass is closed," he said. "A great wall of snow has fallen across the trail. We cannot cross it."

Sam put down the cup in his hand. "Then we turn back."

"The road behind us is no better. White Creek will be covered with ice, and the path down the hill is dangerous. We should try the lower valley."

"You said the lower valley was hard to find."

"It is. I was hoping the high path would stay open. It did not."

There were no angry words, only tired faces. The travelers knew Caleb had not made the weather. But they also knew that a wrong choice could cost them more than their food.

Rose opened Henry Ellis's rough drawing on the table. The paper was soft where snow had wet it. She placed a stone at each corner. "Henry drew the lower path here," she said. "It goes down beside a stream, then turns toward a line of trees."

"The stream may be under the snow," Jonah said.

"And the trees may all look the same," Will added.

Agnes touched the paper. "There is a village marked here, near the river."

Caleb looked closely. "That is not a village. It is the old stone shelter. Miners built it many years ago. It has a strong roof and a place for a fire. If we reach it, we can rest before the last part of the journey."

"How far?" Sam asked.

"One long day if the snow is firm. Perhaps two."

Sam walked to the door. Through the opening he could see only whiteness. "We have food for less than two days."

"Then every hour matters," Caleb said. "But an hour of careful walking is worth more than an hour of running in the wrong direction."

They prepared to leave. Rose gave her books to Agnes, who placed them beneath the blankets on Queen's back. Will asked if he could keep the small school bell in his pocket. Rose nodded. Nobody laughed this time. In the snow, even a broken bell seemed worth carrying.

The group walked downhill through a quiet forest. Snow covered fallen branches and holes in the ground. Caleb tested the path with his staff. Jonah walked near the animals and told them to move slowly. Rose followed with Will. Agnes brought up the back and watched that nobody fell behind.

Around midday, Caleb stopped beside a group of trees. He looked left, then right. The stream was nowhere to be seen.

"I do not like this," he said.

"What is wrong?" Rose asked.

"The land is different from the way I remember it. A tree fell here many years ago. It should be in front of us, but I cannot find it."

Sam pointed downhill. "Everything goes down to the river. Let us go down."

"Not every slope ends at the river. Some end at cliffs."

Rose walked to a small rise where she could see through the trees. There was a sound beneath the snow. Not wind. Water. She knelt and pressed her hand against a dark place in the white ground. A little stream moved under thin ice.

"Here," she called. "I can hear it."

Caleb came and looked. "We found the stream. Good work."

"I heard it because I stopped talking," Rose said.

"A useful skill," Agnes answered, looking meaningfully at Sam.

They followed the stream from a safe distance, staying above the bank where the ground was firm. It led them between two hills. The light began to fade early, as it does in the mountains in late autumn. The animals grew tired. Will stumbled twice, and Rose could see that his legs were shaking.

"We need to stop," she said.

Sam looked at the dark sky. "We are nearly at the shelter."

"You do not know that," Rose answered. "And Will cannot walk much farther."

Caleb turned to the boy. "Tell me the truth."

Will wanted to say he was fine. Instead he shook his head. "I am very tired."

Caleb nodded. "Then we stop for ten minutes, eat a small piece of bread, and go on only if everyone can walk."

Sam sat beside Will. Without speaking, he took a little food from his own pocket and passed it to him. Rose watched but said nothing. She knew the gift was easier for Sam when nobody spoke of it.

The evening became darker. Somewhere beyond the trees, the stream ran under the ice. Caleb lit a small lantern and held it low. He had never looked so uncertain. Yet when Will stood again, Caleb was the first to offer him an arm.

"The lower road," Caleb said quietly, "was not the easiest choice. But it is the choice we made together. We will finish it together too."

CHAPTER 7

# Chapter 7: The Stone Shelter

At the end of the valley they found the shelter. It was not a pretty building. Its walls were made of dark stone, and its roof was covered with snow. One window was small and square. The wooden door was heavy, but it still opened. Inside there was a stone fireplace, a wooden bench, and a shelf with three empty bottles.

"The finest hotel in the mountains," Agnes announced. "This one even has a door."



Will sat on the bench and laughed. He had not laughed for two days. Jonah checked the animals outside, where a wall kept the wind

away. Then he brought in dry branches that he had found beneath the low part of the roof.

They built a small fire. Agnes used the last beans and a little water to make a thin soup. She divided it into six cups. No cup was larger than another. It tasted wonderful because everybody was hungry.

Sam looked at the empty food bag. "I am sorry," he said suddenly.

Caleb raised his eyes. "For what?"

"For pushing everybody to hurry. I was thinking about my sister. I was not thinking enough about the mountain."

"You were worried about your family," Rose said. "That is not wrong."

"It was wrong to believe that worry could make the snow disappear."

Caleb put his cup down. "All of us wanted the short road. I chose it too. I have crossed this pass many times, but I still have to listen when the mountain tells me no."

The conversation made the room warmer than the fire. They were not six perfect travelers. They had each made mistakes. But they had not left anyone behind.

Later, Agnes found something beneath the bench. It was a small tin box. She opened it and showed the others a needle, a length of strong thread, and three metal buttons. "Someone was kind enough to leave a useful treasure," she said.

She used the thread to repair Will's torn coat and one of Jonah's gloves. Rose turned the needle in her hand when Agnes was finished.

"I thought we needed something large to save us," she said. "A new wagon, perhaps, or a train."

"Sometimes all you need is a needle," Agnes replied. "Or someone who knows how to use it."

Near midnight, a sound came from outside. Queen was moving against the wall. Jonah opened the door just enough to look out. He came back looking frightened.

"The snow is falling from the ridge above the shelter," he said. "Not a great fall, but enough to frighten the horses."

Caleb and Sam went out to check the land. A small line of snow had come down a steep slope behind the building. It had stopped well before the wall. Caleb studied the slope by lantern light.

"We cannot stay here through another storm," he said when he returned. "The shelter is strong, but the path below may close. We must leave at first light."

Rose heard the words and looked at Will. He was asleep on the floor under a blanket. She wanted to give him one more day of rest. Yet she knew that rest could become a danger of its own.

In the morning they packed before the sun appeared. They had almost no food, but the animals had found dry grass beneath the snow by the wall. Jonah brushed Queen's coat and thanked her for carrying the books. She moved her head against him, hoping for more oats.

"No more oats today," he told her. "Perhaps in Silver Creek."

They walked for an hour. Then a sudden cry came from the back of the group. Sam had fallen on a hidden stone. He tried to stand but could not put his full weight on his right foot.

Agnes knelt beside him. "A bad twist," she said. "The boot can stay on for now. But we must tie the ankle."

"I can walk," Sam said, rising too quickly. He took one step and nearly fell again.

Caleb held him. "You can walk with help. We will change the loads."

Jonah took Sam's heavy bag. Will carried the lighter tools. Rose gave Sam her staff. With an arm around Caleb's shoulder, Sam moved slowly down the path.

He was angry with himself, and he hated that the others had to wait. Rose walked beside him for a while.

"You pulled Jonah out of the creek," she said. "Did you stop to ask if he could pay you back?"

"Of course not."

"Then let us help you without asking for payment."

Sam looked at her and smiled a little. "You sound like a schoolteacher."

"I am one. Even without a school."

CHAPTER 8

# Chapter 8: Beyond the Pass

The last ridge stood between the travelers and the valley of Silver Creek. From the top, Caleb said, they would be able to see the railway line. The trouble was the path along the ridge. Snow had covered most of its stones, and the wind had made hard ice on the narrow places.

They reached the beginning of the ridge shortly after noon. Caleb stopped and checked the rope. The high side of the path was a wall of rock. The low side fell into a steep valley. There was room for people to walk, but the animals would need another way.



"We cannot take Queen here," Jonah said. He spoke as calmly as he could, but his hands were tight around the rope.

Caleb looked toward a line of trees below. "You are right. There is a lower track. Take the animals that way with Agnes. Wait at the large stone near the end. We will meet you there."

Agnes studied him for a moment. "I know a safe track when I see one. If the lower one is bad, we will stop and wait."

"Good."

Jonah led the animals toward the trees. Their bells made a quiet sound in the cold air. Agnes followed close behind. Rose watched until they were hidden by the branches. Then she turned to the ridge.

Caleb tied the rope around his waist, and the others held it in a line. Sam stayed behind him, walking carefully on his injured foot. Rose went next, with Will last. They moved slowly, one careful step after another. The wind was so strong that they could not speak easily.

At the narrowest point, Will stopped. He looked down and saw a long drop between the rocks. His hands began to shake.

"I cannot do this," he said.

Rose turned her head. "Look at me, not down."

"My legs will not move."

"They will. Put your foot beside mine. Only one step."

Will tried, but he was frightened. Caleb stopped ahead and waited. He knew that pulling the rope would make things worse.

"Listen," Rose said. "Do you remember when you carried my box out of the school?"

"Yes."

"You said you were strong enough. You are still strong. But being strong does not mean you cannot be afraid. It means you can take a careful step while you are afraid."

Will closed his eyes for a moment. Then he looked at her boots and moved one foot. The next step was easier. Soon they reached a wider part of the trail.

They rested against the rock wall. Sam sat on a flat stone and breathed hard. "I do not care if a train is waiting below," he said. "I will never complain about a slow train again."

Caleb looked to the west. The clouds had opened, and sunlight fell on a long valley. Far below, a thin dark line crossed the ground. At one place it disappeared into a line of trees, then returned near a small group of buildings.

"Silver Creek," Caleb said. "There it is."

Rose could see a little square roof and a dark column of smoke. Somewhere in the valley, a train whistle sounded. It was a low, distant note, almost lost in the wind.

Will took the broken school bell from his pocket and rang it. Its small sound was nothing beside the mountains, but he smiled as if he had rung the bell of the whole town.

They continued until the path joined the lower track. Agnes and Jonah were waiting with the animals by the large stone. Queen had found grass and was eating as if she had never known danger. Jonah waved both arms.

"We are here!" he shouted. "All three animals, and Agnes too!"

"He counts the animals before me," Agnes called. "I should be offended, but Queen is probably more useful."

For the first time in many days, they could walk without looking at the sky every minute. The valley road became wider. Snow changed to mud, then to firm brown earth. They passed a small farm and a fence made from cut pine trees. At the farm, an old woman saw their tired faces and brought out a jug of warm milk and six pieces of bread.

Rose wanted to refuse because the woman had so little, but the woman smiled. "People helped my family when we came here. Now I can help yours."

The travelers thanked her and ate slowly. Sam gave Will the largest piece, and Agnes pretended not to notice. The bread tasted richer than any meal they remembered.

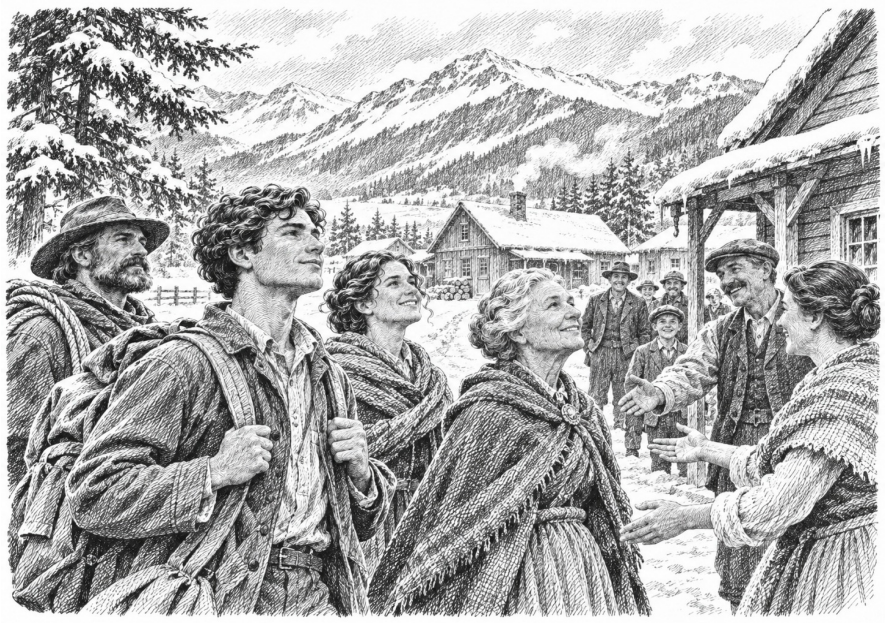
As evening came, they saw the station lamps of Silver Creek. The mountains behind them were already dark. The narrow ridge was hidden in cloud again. But this time they were below it, walking together toward the light.

CHAPTER 9

# Chapter 9: The Sound of the Train

The people at Silver Creek stared when the six travelers entered the station yard. Their clothes were dirty, their boots were wet, and their faces were red from the cold. They looked as if they had walked out of another world.

A station worker led the horses to a warm shed. Another man brought the group into a room with a stove. Somebody put a large pot of soup on the table. For several minutes nobody spoke. They were too busy eating and feeling the warmth return to their hands.



Rose took out her notebook and wrote the date: November 3, 1893. She had meant to arrive several days earlier. The journey had

taken longer than anyone expected. She counted the things they had lost: a bag of flour, a hat, two gloves, and the hope of an easy crossing. Then she counted the things they had kept: six people, three animals, and the chance to begin again.

Sam found his sister near the railway office. Her name was Ellen, and she came running when she heard his voice. Two children followed her. Sam lifted the smaller child and sat down because his injured foot hurt. He showed Ellen the money he had carried in his coat.

"You should have taken the long road," she said, holding his hand.

"Perhaps," Sam answered. "I wanted to be here quickly. Then I learned that getting here at all was more important."

Ellen looked at the others and thanked them. Sam gave a short laugh. "They did the walking. And the talking. Especially Agnes."

"Talking kept you alive," Agnes replied. "You should try it more often."

Caleb spoke with the station master about the snow on the pass. He warned him not to send travelers over the high road until it was safe. The station master wrote down his words and promised to tell the next wagon party.

Jonah put Queen in a warm stall and gave her a full bucket of oats. She ate without looking up. "You have earned them," he said. Then he lay on a bench outside the stall and fell asleep at once.

Will was offered a place at the railway workshop. A mechanic told him there was work cleaning tools and learning how the machines fitted together. Will asked if he could begin the next day. The

mechanic looked at his tired face and said, "Begin after you sleep. We want a boy who can stay awake near an engine."

Rose visited the new school that afternoon. It was a small wooden building beside the station road. The teacher who had written to her showed her the room and the children's books. On the front wall hung a clock. It had stopped at three.

"We will repair it soon," the woman said.

"I have something else that needs repair," Rose answered. She took the little broken bell from her pocket. The handle was bent, but the metal still rang. "Perhaps the children can use it until the clock works."

The woman smiled. "There is a place for it here."

That evening the six travelers met again for supper. Caleb was leaving in a few days to guide another group along the safer valley road, after the weather improved. Agnes had been offered work in a boarding house. Sam would stay with his sister until his ankle healed. Jonah wanted to care for horses at the railway yard. Will could hardly stop speaking about engines.

Rose looked around the table. They had begun as travelers who wanted to reach the same place. Now they were friends who knew how much could happen on a single road.

"What was the hardest part?" Will asked.

"The cold," Jonah said.

"The food," Agnes answered. "Or rather, the lack of it."

"The waiting," Sam said. "I wanted to move, even when moving was foolish."

Caleb thought for a long time. "For me, the hardest part was saying I did not know. A guide should know the way. But sometimes the right words are: I am not certain. We must look again."

Rose looked at the small fire beside the table. "I think the hardest part was learning that we needed one another. I wanted to be brave enough to manage everything myself. That was not real courage."

"What is real courage?" Will asked.

"Perhaps it is helping someone, even when you are afraid," Rose said. "And accepting help when you need it."

The next morning a train came into Silver Creek with a long whistle. Rose stood outside the school and watched the steam rise into the cold air. The mountains were hidden behind the clouds. She knew they would stay there long after the people who crossed them had gone.

A group of children hurried toward the school. One boy asked why she had a small bell with a broken handle. Rose told him she had carried it over a mountain pass. His eyes became wide.

"Was it a great adventure?" he asked.

"Yes," Rose said. "But the best part was not the mountain. It was the people who helped me reach the other side."

She rang the bell. The children went inside, and a new school day began.

# Glossary · 40 Words

*Useful words from the story, in alphabetical order*

Read each word, its meaning, and the example. Return to the story when you need help.

| Word | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **blanket** | a warm covering used when sleeping | They tied the blankets behind the saddles. |
| **bridge** | a structure used to cross water or a gap | The old wooden bridge was unsafe. |
| **cabin** | a small simple house, often made of wood | Henry waited outside his cabin. |
| **canvas** | strong cloth used for bags and covers | The food was kept in canvas bags. |
| **careful** | taking time to avoid mistakes or danger | They made a careful choice about the road. |
| **cliff** | a high, steep side of a rock or mountain | The path ran beside a steep cliff. |
| **cloud** | a white or grey shape in the sky | A dark cloud moved over the ridge. |
| **creek** | a small river or stream | White Creek was full of cold water. |
| **current** | the movement of water in one direction | The current carried away the flour bag. |
| **danger** | the possibility of being hurt | Caleb chose the smaller danger. |

| Word | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **engine** | a machine that gives power to a vehicle | Will hoped to repair railway engines. |
| **flour** | powder made from grain, used to make bread | Some of the flour was lost in the creek. |
| **fork** | a place where a road divides into two | They turned left at the second fork. |
| **guide** | someone who shows people a safe route | Caleb was the travelers' mountain guide. |
| **injured** | hurt in an accident | Sam rested his injured foot. |
| **inn** | a small place where travelers can eat or sleep | Agnes had once kept the town inn. |
| **journey** | travel from one place to another | The mountain journey took longer than planned. |
| **matches** | small sticks used to start a fire | The matches stayed dry inside a box. |
| **mule** | an animal often used to carry heavy things | Queen was a clever brown mule. |
| **narrow** | having little space from one side to the other | The travelers walked along a narrow path. |
| **oats** | a type of grain fed to animals | Jonah gave the mule some oats. |
| **pass** | a route through mountains | They crossed Falcon Pass before winter. |
| **peak** | the pointed top of a mountain | A cloud formed over the highest peak. |

| Word | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **railway** | a system of tracks used by trains | Silver Creek had a railway station. |
| **repair** | to make something work again | Will wanted to repair engines. |
| **ridge** | a long high part of a mountain | The wind crossed the western ridge. |
| **glove** | a covering for your hand | Caleb took off one glove in the cold. |
| **rope** | a strong thick line used to tie or pull | Caleb used a rope to help the travelers. |
| **saddle** | a seat placed on a horse's back | Blankets were tied behind the saddles. |
| **shelter** | a place that protects people from weather | The travelers searched for shelter. |
| **slope** | a piece of land that rises or falls | The rocky slope was hard to climb. |
| **snow** | soft white pieces of frozen water from clouds | Fresh snow covered the high trail. |
| **stable** | a building where horses are kept | The group met at the stable. |
| **station** | a place where trains stop | They reached the Silver Creek station. |
| **storm** | a period of dangerous weather | The storm blocked the mountain road. |
| **stream** | a small river | A stream ran near the old bridge. |

| Word | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **supplies** | food and other things needed for a journey | They counted their supplies after the accident. |
| **trail** | a path through the countryside | The trail ran close to a high rock wall. |
| **valley** | low land between hills or mountains | They could see the valley below. |
| **whistle** | a high sound made to give a signal | They heard the whistle of a train. |

# Reading Comprehension

*Choose A, B, or C after reading the complete story.*

1. Why was Rose leaving Pine Crossing?

   A. Her school had closed.
   B. She wanted to buy a horse.
   C. She disliked the mountains.

2. What work did Will hope to learn?

   A. Baking bread
   B. Repairing railway engines
   C. Keeping an inn

3. What was the name of the mule?

   A. Queen
   B. Daisy
   C. Hope

4. Why did Caleb take an extra day of food?

   A. He wanted to sell it.
   B. He expected visitors.
   C. The weather could change.

5. What warning did Henry Ellis give?

   A. The high road was icy.
   B. The bridge in town was new.
   C. The station was closed.

6. Which path did the group take at the two-trunk tree?

A. The right path
B. The left path
C. The river path

7. What happened to Queen at White Creek?

A. She ran into the forest.
B. She broke the bridge.
C. She slipped between stones.

8. What did the travelers lose in the water?

A. A bag of flour
B. All their matches
C. The school bell

9. What did Agnes do when supplies ran low?

A. She returned home.
B. She carefully planned the meals.
C. She bought food at the station.

10. Why could the travelers not simply hurry?

A. The road was unsafe.
B. They were waiting for a festival.
C. Their train was early.

11. Who often tried to move faster than the others?

A. Jonah
B. Rose
C. Sam

12. What did Caleb learn was important for a guide?

A. Never listening to others
B. Admitting when he was uncertain
C. Traveling alone

13. Where did the travelers finally arrive?

A. Silver Creek
B. Pine Crossing
C. Birch Creek

14. Who was waiting for Sam?

A. His teacher
B. His sister Ellen
C. His grandfather

15. What new work did Will find?

A. At the railway workshop
B. At an old mine
C. At an inn

16. What did Rose bring to her new school?

A. A silver watch
B. A new clock
C. A broken school bell

17. What did Jonah give Queen in the warm stall?

A. Sugar
B. Oats
C. Apples

18. What did Rose say mattered most about her adventure?

A. The people who helped her
B. The cold weather
C. The height of the mountains

# Short Answer Questions

*Write one or two sentences for each question.*

1. Why does Rose keep the broken school bell?

2. Why does Caleb disagree with Sam about the weather?

3. What is the meaning of Henry Ellis's warning?

4. How do the travelers help Jonah in White Creek?

5. How does the loss of food change the group's plans?

6. What makes Will afraid on the narrow path?

7. How does the group show courage during the journey?

8. How are the travelers different at the end of the story?

# Think · Speak · Write

*Talk with a partner, then write your ideas in English.*

1. Would you choose the shorter mountain pass or the longer valley road? Why?

2. How can someone be brave and afraid at the same time?

3. Which character would you trust as a traveling companion? Explain.

4. What should a group do when its leader is not sure of the way?

5. Which moment in the story showed the strongest teamwork?

6. Why was Rose's broken bell important to the ending?

# Writing Task

Write 100–120 words about a difficult journey or a time when you helped someone.

Use the past simple and words from the glossary. Include where you were, what went wrong, who helped you, and what you learned.

Title: _____

# Final Test

*20 questions · Vocabulary, Grammar, and Story*

**Part A - Vocabulary (8 questions)**

1. A ___ is a place where horses are kept.

A. stable
B. valley
C. station

2. A ___ is a route through mountains.

A. creek
B. pass
C. rope

3. A ___ is a small river.

A. engine
B. saddle
C. creek

4. You use ___ to start a fire.

A. matches
B. oats
C. saddles

5. To ___ an engine means to make it work again.

A. climb
B. repair
C. borrow

6. A strong line used for pulling is a ___.

A. cloud
B. cabin
C. rope

7. A ___ is a long high part of a mountain.

A. ridge
B. kettle
C. station

8. A ___ is a warm covering for sleeping.

A. bridge
B. blanket
C. mule

**Part B - Grammar (6 questions)**

9. Rose ___ in Pine Crossing for two years before leaving.

A. teach
B. taught
C. teaching

10. The travelers ___ the left road at the fork.

A. take
B. taking
C. took

11. If it snows heavily, the path ___ dangerous.

A. becomes
B. become
C. becoming

12. Sam was tired, ___ he continued helping.

A. because
B. but
C. or

13. The river was ___ than they expected.

A. cold
B. coldest
C. colder

14. They ___ Silver Creek after a difficult journey.

A. reached
B. reaching
C. reaches

**Part C - The Story (6 questions)**

15. Where did Rose hope to work?

A. At a sawmill
B. At a new school
C. In a mine

16. Who told them about the icy upper road?

A. Henry Ellis
B. Will
C. Ellen

17. What happened in White Creek?

A. A train stopped.
B. The bell broke.
C. A flour bag was lost.

18. Who was the guide?

A. Sam Reed
B. Caleb Ward
C. Jonah Finch

19. Where did Sam meet his sister?

A. At Silver Creek
B. On the high ridge
C. At the old mine

20. What did Rose ring for the children?

A. A dinner bell
B. A new railway bell
C. Her old school bell

**Score: _____ / 20**

# Answer Key

*Check your answers after you finish all the activities.*

**Reading Comprehension**

1. A 2. B 3. A 4. C 5. A 6. B 7. C 8. A 9. B

10. A 11. C 12. B 13. A 14. B 15. A 16. C 17. B 18. A

**Final Test**

1. A 2. B 3. C 4. A 5. B 6. C 7. A 8. B 9. B 10. C

11. A 12. B 13. C 14. A 15. B 16. A 17. C 18. B 19. A 20. C

**Short Answers – Sample Ideas**

1. She brought the bell to Pine Crossing and wants to keep a part of her old school.

2. He knows the weather can change quickly beyond the mountains.

3. The high road may be covered with ice, so they must think about the safer route.

4. Sam catches Jonah and Caleb uses the long rope to help pull them out.

5. They must plan meals carefully and avoid wasting food.

6. The path is narrow and dangerous, and he is afraid of falling.

7. They share food, help injured travelers, and listen to one another.

8. They arrive as friends who understand cooperation and courage better.

Discussion and writing questions can have more than one good answer.

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# Beyond the Frozen Pass

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